Chapter LIX

Noble Natures Never Lose Courage, Nor Good Stomachs Their Appetites

THE little troop, without looking behind them or exchanging a word, fled at a rapid gallop, fording a little stream, of which none of them knew the name, and leaving on their left a town which Athos declared to be Durham. At last they came in sight of a small wood, and spurring their horses afresh, rode in its direction.

As soon as they had disappeared behind a green curtain sufficiently thick to conceal them from the sight of any one who might be in pursuit they drew up to hold a council together. The two grooms held the horses, that they might take a little rest without being unsaddled, and Grimaud was posted as sentinel.

'Come, first of all,' said Athos to D'Artagnan, 'my friend, that I may shake hands with you—you, our rescuer—you, the true hero of us all.'

'Athos is right—you have my adoration,' said Aramis, in his turn pressing his hand. 'To what are you not equal, with your superior intelligence, infallible eye, your arm of iron and your enterprising mind!'

'Now,' said the Gascon, 'that is all well, I accept for Porthos and myself everything—thanks and compliments; we have plenty of time to spare.'

The two friends, recalled by D'Artagnan to what was also due to Porthos, pressed his hand in their turn.

'And now,' said Athos, 'it is not our plan to run anywhere and like madmen, but we must map up our campaign. What shall we do?'

'What are we going to do, i'faith? It is not very difficult to say.'

'Tell us, then, D'Artagnan.'

'We are going to reach the nearest seaport, unite our little resources, hire a vessel and return to France. As for me I will give my last sou for it. Life is the greatest treasure, and speaking candidly, ours hangs by a thread.'

'What do you say to this, Du Vallon?'

'I,' said Porthos, 'I am entirely of D'Artagnan's opinion; this is a "beastly" country, this England.'

'You are quite decided, then, to leave it?' asked Athos of D'Artagnan.

'Egad! I don't see what is to keep me here.'

A glance was exchanged between Athos and Aramis.

'Go, then, my friends,' said the former, sighing.

'How, go then?' exclaimed D'Artagnan. 'Let us go, you mean?'

'No, my friend,' said Athos, 'you must leave us.'

'Leave you!' cried D'Artagnan, quite bewildered at this unexpected announcement.

'Bah!' said Porthos, 'why separate, since we are all together?'

'Because you can and ought to return to France; your mission is accomplished, but ours is not.'

'Your mission is not accomplished?' exclaimed D'Artagnan, looking in astonishment at Athos.

'No, my friend,' replied Athos, in his gentle but decided voice, 'we came here to defend King Charles; we have but ill defended him—it remains for us to save him!'

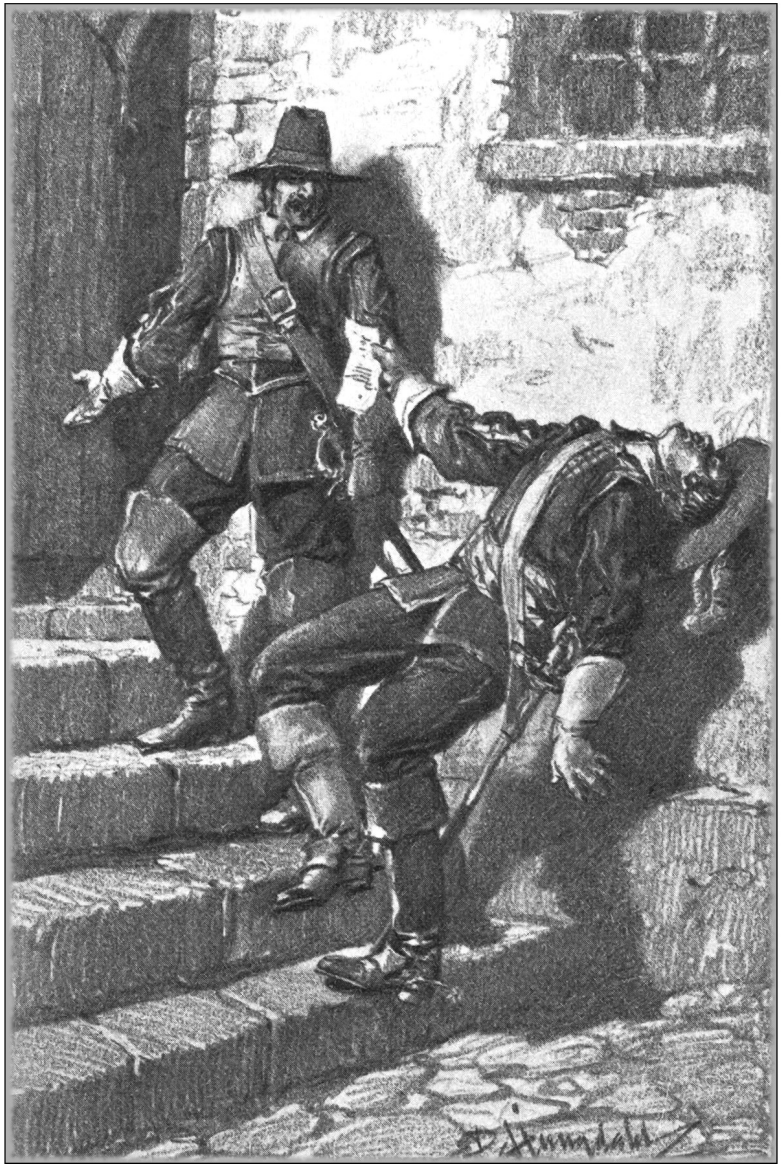
'To save the king?' said D'Artagnan, looking at Aramis as he had looked at Athos.

Aramis contented himself by making a sign with his head.

D'Artagnan's countenance took an expression of the deepest compassion; he began to think he had to do with madmen.

'You cannot be speaking seriously, Athos!' said he; 'the king is surrounded by an army, which is conducting him to London. This army is commanded by a butcher, or the son of a butcher—it matters little—Colonel Harrison. His majesty, I can assure you, will be tried on his arrival in London; I have heard enough from the lips of Oliver Cromwell to know what to expect.'

A second look was exchanged between Athos and Aramis.



Mordaunt fell on the stone steps

There, caressing as he pretended, the animal with his hand, he put this bit of burning tinder in his ear. It was necessary to be as good a horseman as he was to risk such a scheme, for no sooner had the animal felt the burning tinder than he uttered a cry of pain and reared and jumped as if he had been mad.

The soldiers, whom he was nearly trampling, ran away.

'Help! help!' cried D'Artagnan; 'stop—my horse has the staggers.'

In an instant the horse's eyes grew bloodshot and he was white with foam.

'Help!' cried D'Artagnan. 'What! will you let me be killed? *Jésus Seigneur!*'

No sooner had he uttered this cry than the door opened and Athos and Aramis rushed out. The coast, owing to the Gascon's stratagem, was clear.

'The prisoners are escaping! the prisoners are escaping!' cried the sergeant.

'Stop! stop!' cried D'Artagnan, giving rein to his famous steed, who, darting forth, overturned several men.

'Stop! stop!' cried the soldiers, and ran for their arms.

But the prisoners were in their saddles and lost no time hastening to the nearest gate.

In the middle of the street they saw Grimaud and Blaisois, who were coming to find their masters. With one wave of his hand Athos made Grimaud, who followed the little troop, understand everything, and they passed on like a whirlwind, D'Artagnan still directing them from behind with his voice.

They passed through the gate like apparitions, without the guards thinking of detaining them, and reached the open country.

All this time the soldiers were calling out, 'Stop! stop!' and the sergeant, who began to see that he was the victim of an artifice, was almost in a frenzy of despair. Whilst all this was going on, a cavalier in full gallop was seen approaching. It was Mordaunt with the order in his hand.

'The prisoners!' he exclaimed, jumping off his horse.

The sergeant had not the courage to reply; he showed him the open door, the empty room. Mordaunt darted to the steps, understood all, uttered a cry, as if his very heart was pierced, and fell fainting on the stone steps.

'And when the trial is ended there will be no delay in putting the sentence into execution,' continued D'Artagnan.

'And to what penalty do you think the king will be condemned?' asked Athos.

'The penalty of death, I greatly fear; they have gone too far for him to pardon them, and there is nothing left to them but one thing, and that is to kill him. Have you never heard what Oliver Cromwell said when he came to Paris and was shown the dungeon at Vincennes where Monsieur de Vendôme was imprisoned?'

'What did he say?' asked Porthos.

'"Princes must be knocked on the head."'

'I remember it,' said Athos.

'And you fancy he will not put his maxim into execution, now that he has got hold of the king?'

'On the contrary, I am certain he will do so. But then that is all the more reason why we should not abandon the august head so threatened.'

'Athos, you are becoming mad.'

'No, my friend,' Athos gently replied, 'but De Winter sought us out in France and introduced us, Monsieur d'Herblay and myself, to Madame Henrietta. Her majesty did us the honour to ask our aid for her husband. We engaged our word; our word included everything. It was our strength, our intelligence, our life, in short, that we promised. It remains now for us to keep our word. Is that your opinion, D'Herblay?'

'Yes,' said Aramis, 'we have promised.'

'Then,' continued Athos, 'we have another reason; it is this—listen: In France at this moment everything is poor and paltry. We have a king ten years old, who doesn't yet know what he wants; we have a queen blinded by a belated passion; we have a minister who governs France as he would govern a great farm—that is to say, intent only on turning out all the gold he can by the exercise of Italian cunning and invention; we have princes who set up a personal and egotistic opposition, who will draw from Mazarin's hands only a few ingots of gold or some shreds of power granted as bribes. I have served them without enthusiasm—God knows that I estimated them at their real value, and that they are not high in my esteem—but on principle. To-day I am engaged in a different affair. I have encountered misfortune in a high place,

a royal misfortune, a European misfortune; I attach myself to it. If we can succeed in saving the king it will be good; if we die for him it will be grand.'

'So you know beforehand you must perish!' said D'Artagnan.

'We fear so, and our only regret is to die so far from both of *you*.'

'What will you do in a foreign land, an enemy's country?'

'I traveled in England when I was young, I speak English like an Englishman, and Aramis, too, knows something of the language. Ah! if we had you, my friends! With you, D'Artagnan, with you, Porthos—all four reunited for the first time for twenty years—we would dare not only England, but the three kingdoms put together!'

'And did you promise the queen,' resumed D'Artagnan, petulantly, 'to storm the Tower of London, to kill a hundred thousand soldiers, to fight victoriously against the wishes of the nation and the ambition of a man, and when that man is Cromwell? Do not exaggerate your duty. In Heaven's name, my dear Athos, do not make a useless sacrifice. When I see you merely, you look like a reasonable being; when you speak, I seem to have to do with a madman. Come, Porthos, join me; say frankly, what do you think of this business?'

'Nothing good,' replied Porthos.

'Come,' continued D'Artagnan, who, irritated that instead of listening to him Athos seemed to be attending to his own thoughts, 'you have never found yourself the worse for my advice. Well, then, believe me, Athos, your mission is ended, and ended nobly; return to France with us.'

'Friend,' said Athos, 'our resolution is irrevocable.'

'Then you have some other motive unknown to us?'

Athos smiled and D'Artagnan struck his hands together in anger and muttered the most convincing reasons that he could discover; but to all these reasons Athos contented himself by replying with a calm, sweet smile and Aramis by nodding his head.

'Very well,' cried D'Artagnan, at last, furious, 'very well, since you wish it, let us leave our bones in this beggarly land, where it is always cold, where fine weather is a fog, fog is rain, and rain a deluge; where the sun represents the moon and the moon a cream cheese; in truth, whether we die here or elsewhere matters little, since we must die.'

'Only reflect, my good fellow,' said Athos, 'it is but dying rather sooner.'

'Do you see that street? There are the horses. Go out by the door, turn to the right, jump into your saddles, all will be right; don't be uneasy at anything except mistaking the signal. That will be the signal when I call out—*Jésus Seigneur!*'

'But give us your word that you will come too, D'Artagnan,' said Athos.

'I swear I will, by Heaven.'

''Tis settled,' said Aramis; 'at the cry "*Jésus Seigneur*" we go out, upset all that stands in our way, run to our horses, jump into our saddles, spur them; is that all?'

'Exactly.'

'See, Aramis, as I have told you, D'Artagnan is first amongst us all,' said Athos.

'Very true,' replied the Gascon, 'but I always run away from compliments. Don't forget the signal: "*Jésus Seigneur!*"' and he went out as he came in, whistling the self-same air.

The soldiers were playing or sleeping; two of them were singing in a corner, out of tune, the psalm: 'On the rivers of Babylon.'

D'Artagnan called the sergeant. 'My dear friend, General Cromwell has sent Monsieur Mordaunt to fetch me. Guard the prisoners well, I beg of you.'

The sergeant made a sign, as much as to say he did not understand French, and D'Artagnan tried to make him comprehend by signs and gestures. Then he went into the stable; he found the five horses saddled, his own amongst the rest.

'Each of you take a horse by the bridle,' he said to Porthos and Mousqueton; 'turn to the left, so that Athos and Aramis may see you clearly from the window.'

'They are coming, then?' said Porthos.

'In a moment.'

'You didn't forget my purse?'

'No; be easy.'

'Good.'

Porthos and Mousqueton each took a horse by the bridle and proceeded to their post.

Then D'Artagnan, being alone, struck a light and lighted a small bit of tinder, mounted his horse and stopped at the door in the midst of the soldiers.

therefore, not only to fetch the order, but the two thousand pistoles, at which he estimated the prisoners. He therefore mounted his horse and disappeared.

'Good!' thought D'Artagnan; 'a quarter of an hour to go to the tent, a quarter of an hour to return; it is more than we need.' Then turning, without the least change of countenance, to Porthos, he said, looking him full in the face: 'Friend Porthos, listen to this; first, not a syllable to either of our friends of what you have heard; it is unnecessary for them to know the service we are going to render them.'

'Very well; I understand.'

'Go to the stable; you will find Mousqueton there; saddle your horses, put your pistols in your saddle-bags, take out the horses and lead them to the street below this, so that there will be nothing to do but mount them; all the rest is my business.'

Porthos made no remark, but obeyed, with the sublime confidence he had in his friend.

'I go,' he said, 'only, shall I enter the chamber where those gentlemen are?'

'No, it is not worth while.'

'Well, do me the kindness to take my purse, which I left on the mantelpiece.'

'All right.'

He then proceeded, with his usual calm gait, to the stable and went into the very midst of the soldiery, who, foreigner as he was, could not help admiring his height and the enormous strength of his great limbs.

At the corner of the street he met Mousqueton and took him with him.

D'Artagnan, meantime, went into the house, whistling a tune which he had begun before Porthos went away.

'My dear Athos, I have reflected on your arguments and I am convinced. I am sorry to have had anything to do with this matter. As you say, Mazarin is a knave. I have resolved to fly with you, not a word—be ready. Your swords are in the corner; do not forget them, they are in many circumstances very useful; there is Porthos's purse, too.'

He put it into his pocket. The two friends were perfectly stupefied.

'Well, pray, is there anything to be so surprised at?' he said. 'I was blind; Athos has made me see, that's all; come here.'

The two friends went near him.

'Pooh! a little sooner or a little later, it isn't worth quarrelling over.'

'If I am astonished at anything,' remarked Porthos, sententiously, 'it is that it has not already happened.'

'Oh, it will happen, you may be sure,' said D'Artagnan. 'So it is agreed, and if Porthos makes no objection— '

'I,' said Porthos, 'I will do whatever you please; and besides, I think what the Comte de la Fère said just now is very good.'

'But your future career, D'Artagnan—your ambition, Porthos?'

'Our future, our ambition!' replied D'Artagnan, with feverish volubility. 'Need we think of that since we are to save the king? The king saved—we shall assemble our friends together—we will head the Puritans—reconquer England; we shall re-enter London—place him securely on his throne— '

'And he will make us dukes and peers,' said Porthos, whose eyes sparkled with joy at this imaginary prospect.

'Or he will forget us,' added D'Artagnan.

'Oh!' said Porthos.

'Well, that has happened, friend Porthos. It seems to me that we once rendered Anne of Austria a service not much less than that which to-day we are trying to perform for Charles I.; but, none the less, Anne of Austria has forgotten us for twenty years.'

'Well, in spite of that, D'Artagnan,' said Athos, 'you are not sorry that you were useful to her?'

'No, indeed,' said D'Artagnan; 'I admit even that in my darkest moments I find consolation in that remembrance.'

'You see, then, D'Artagnan, though princes often are ungrateful, God never is.'

'Athos,' said D'Artagnan, 'I believe that were you to fall in with the devil, you would conduct yourself so well that you would take him with you to Heaven.'

'So, then?' said Athos, offering his hand to D'Artagnan.

''Tis settled,' replied D'Artagnan. 'I find England a charming country, and I stay—but on one condition only.'

'What is it?'

'That I am not forced to learn English.'

'Well, now,' said Athos, triumphantly, 'I swear to you, my friend, by the God who hears us—I believe that there is a power watching over us, and that we shall all four see France again.'

'So be it!' said D'Artagnan, 'but I—I confess I have a contrary conviction.'

'Our good D'Artagnan,' said Aramis, 'represents among us the opposition in parliament, which always says *no*, and always does *aye*.'

'But in the meantime saves the country,' added Athos.

'Well, now that everything is decided,' cried Porthos, rubbing his hands, 'suppose we think of dinner! It seems to me that in the most critical positions of our lives we have always dined.'

'Oh! yes, speak of dinner in a country where for a feast they eat boiled mutton, and as a treat drink beer. What the devil did you come to such a country for, Athos? But I forgot,' added the Gascon, smiling, 'pardon, I forgot you are no longer Athos; but never mind, let us hear your plan for dinner, Porthos.'

'My plan!'

'Yes, have you a plan?'

'No! I am hungry, that is all.'

'*Pardieu*, if that is all, I am hungry, too; but it is not everything to be hungry, one must find something to eat, unless we browse on the grass, like our horses— '

'Ah!' exclaimed Aramis, who was not quite so indifferent to the good things of the earth as Athos, 'do you remember, when we were at Parpaillot, the beautiful oysters that we ate?'

'And the legs of mutton of the salt marshes,' said Porthos, smacking his lips.

'But,' suggested D'Artagnan, 'have we not our friend Mousqueton, who managed for us so well at Chantilly, Porthos?'

'Yes,' said Porthos, 'we have Mousqueton, but since he has been steward, he has become very heavy; never mind, let us call him, and to make sure that he will reply agreeably— '

'Here! Mouston,' cried Porthos.

Mouston appeared, with a most piteous face.

'What is the matter, my dear M. Mouston?' asked D'Artagnan. 'Are you ill?'

'Sir, I am very hungry,' replied Mouston.

'Go on, sir, I see what you wish to get at; and if it is simply what I think that stops you, I can obviate the difficulty.'

'Ah, I knew well,' said the Gascon, 'that you were a man of talent. Well, here's the case, here's where the saddle hurts me, as we French say. I am an officer of fortune, nothing else; I have nothing but what my sword brings me in—that is to say, more blows than banknotes. Now, on taking prisoners, this morning, two Frenchmen, who seemed to me of high birth—in short, two knights of the Garter—I said to myself, my fortune is made. I say two, because in such circumstances, Monsieur du Vallon, who is rich, always gives me his prisoners.'

Mordaunt, completely deceived by the wordy civility of D'Artagnan, smiled like a man who understands perfectly the reasons given him, and said:

'I shall have the order signed directly, sir, and with it two thousand pistoles; meanwhile, let me take these men away.'

'No,' replied D'Artagnan; 'what signifies a delay of half an hour? I am a man of order, sir; let us do things in order.'

'Nevertheless,' replied Mordaunt, 'I could compel you; I command here.'

'Ah, sir!' said D'Artagnan, 'I see that although we have had the honour of traveling in your company you do not know us. We are gentlemen; we are, both of us, able to kill you and your eight men—we two only. For Heaven's sake don't be obstinate, for when others are obstinate I am obstinate likewise, and then I become ferocious and headstrong, and there's my friend, who is even more headstrong and ferocious than myself. Besides, we are sent here by Cardinal Mazarin, and at this moment represent both the king and the cardinal, and are, therefore, as ambassadors, able to act with impunity, a thing that General Oliver Cromwell, who is assuredly as great a politician as he is a general, is quite the man to understand. Ask him then, for the written order. What will that cost you my dear Monsieur Mordaunt?'

'Yes, the written order,' said Porthos, who now began to comprehend what D'Artagnan was aiming at, 'we ask only for that.'

However inclined Mordaunt was to have recourse to violence, he understood the reasons D'Artagnan had given him; besides, completely ignorant of the friendship which existed between the four Frenchmen, all his uneasiness disappeared when he heard of the plausible motive of the ransom. He decided,

'Why did you not say so at once, my dear sir! all England is with Cromwell; and since you ask for my prisoners, I bend, sir, to your wishes. They are yours; take them.'

Mordaunt, delighted, advanced, Porthos looking at D'Artagnan with open-mouthed astonishment. Then D'Artagnan trod on his foot and Porthos began to understand that this was merely acting.

Mordaunt put his foot on the first step of the door and, with his hat in hand, prepared to pass by the two friends, motioning to the four men to follow him.

'But, pardon,' said D'Artagnan, with the most charming smile and putting his hand on the young man's shoulder, 'if the illustrious General Oliver Cromwell has disposed of our prisoners in your favour, he has, of course, made that act of donation in writing.'

Mordaunt stopped short.

'He has given you some little writing for me—the least bit of paper which may show that you come in his name. Be pleased to give me that scrap of paper so that I may justify, by a pretext at least, my abandoning my countrymen. Otherwise, you see, although I am sure that General Oliver Cromwell can intend them no harm, it would have a bad appearance.'

Mordaunt recoiled; he felt the blow and discharged a terrible look at D'Artagnan, who responded by the most amiable expression that ever graced a human countenance.

'When I tell you a thing, sir,' said Mordaunt, 'you insult me by doubting it.'

'I!' cried D'Artagnan, 'I doubt what you say! God keep me from it, my dear Monsieur Mordaunt! On the contrary, I take you to be a worthy and accomplished gentleman. And then, sir, do you wish me to speak freely to you?' continued D'Artagnan, with his frank expression.

'Speak out, sir,' said Mordaunt.

'Monsieur du Vallon, yonder, is rich and has forty thousand francs yearly, so he does not care about money. I do not speak for him, but for myself.'

'Well, sir? What more?'

'Well—I—I'm not rich. In Gascony 'tis no dishonour, sir, nobody is rich; and Henry IV, of glorious memory, who was the king of the Gascons, as His Majesty Philip IV is the king of the Spaniards, never had a penny in his pocket.'

'Well, it is just for that reason that we have called you, my good M. Mouston. Could you not procure us a few of those nice little rabbits, and some of those delicious partridges, of which you used to make fricassees at the hotel—? 'Faith, I do not remember the name of the hotel.'

'At the hotel of—,' said Porthos; 'by my faith—nor do I remember it either.'

'It does not matter; and a few of those bottles of old Burgundy wine, which cured your master so quickly of his sprain!'

'Alas! sir,' said Mousqueton, 'I much fear that what you ask for are very rare things in this detestable and barren country, and I think we should do better to go and seek hospitality from the owner of a little house we see on the fringe of the forest.'

'How! is there a house in the neighbourhood?' asked D'Artagnan.

'Yes, sir,' replied Mousqueton.

'Well, let us, as you say, go and ask a dinner from the master of that house. What is your opinion, gentlemen, and does not M. Mouston's suggestion appear to you full of sense?'

'Oh!' said Aramis, 'suppose the master is a Puritan?'

'So much the better, *mordioux!*' replied D'Artagnan; 'if he is a Puritan we will inform him of the capture of the king, and in honour of the news he will kill for us his fatted hens.'

'But if he should be a cavalier?' said Porthos.

'In that case we will put on an air of mourning and he will pluck for us his black fowls.'

'You are very happy,' exclaimed Athos, laughing, in spite of himself, at the sally of the irresistible Gascon; 'for you see the bright side of everything.'

'What would you have?' said D'Artagnan. 'I come from a land where there is not a cloud in the sky.'

'It is not like this, then,' said Porthos stretching out his hand to assure himself whether a chill sensation he felt on his cheek was not really caused by a drop of rain.

'Come, come,' said D'Artagnan, 'more reason why we should start on our journey. Halloo, Grimaud!'

Grimaud appeared.

'Well, Grimaud, my friend, have you seen anything?' asked the Gascon.

'Nothing!' replied Grimaud.

'Those idiots!' cried Porthos, 'they have not even pursued us. Oh! if we had been in their place!'

'Yes, they are wrong,' said D'Artagnan. 'I would willingly have said two words to Mordaunt in this little desert. It is an excellent spot for bringing down a man in proper style.'

'I think, decidedly,' observed Aramis, 'gentlemen, that the son hasn't his mother's energy.'

'What, my good fellow!' replied Athos, 'wait awhile; we have scarcely left him two hours ago—he does not know yet in what direction we came nor where we are. We may say that he is not equal to his mother when we put foot in France, if we are not poisoned or killed before then.'

'Meanwhile, let us dine,' suggested Porthos.

'I'faith, yes,' said Athos, 'for I am hungry.'

'Look out for the black fowls!' cried Aramis.

And the four friends, guided by Mousqueton, took up the way toward the house, already almost restored to their former gayety; for they were now, as Athos had said, all four once more united and of single mind.

'Sir,' replied Mordaunt, 'I have ordered the two prisoners we made this morning to be conducted to my lodging.'

'Wherefore, sir? Excuse curiosity, but I wish to be enlightened on the subject.'

'Because these prisoners, sir, are at my disposal and I choose to dispose of them as I like.'

'Allow me—allow me, sir,' said D'Artagnan, 'to observe you are in error. The prisoners belong to those who take them and not to those who only saw them taken. You might have taken Lord Winter—who, 'tis said, was your uncle—prisoner, but you preferred killing him; 'tis well; we, that is, Monsieur du Vallon and I, could have killed our prisoners—we preferred taking them.'

Mordaunt's very lips grew white with rage.

D'Artagnan now saw that affairs were growing worse and he beat the guard's march upon the door. At the first beat Porthos rushed out and stood on the other side of the door.

This movement was observed by Mordaunt.

'Sir!' he thus addressed D'Artagnan, 'your resistance is useless; these prisoners have just been given me by my illustrious patron, Oliver Cromwell.'

These words struck D'Artagnan like a thunderbolt. The blood mounted to his temples, his eyes became dim; he saw from what fountainhead the ferocious hopes of the young man arose, and he put his hand to the hilt of his sword.

As for Porthos, he looked inquiringly at D'Artagnan.

This look of Porthos's made the Gascon regret that he had summoned the brute force of his friend to aid him in an affair which seemed to require chiefly cunning.

'Violence,' he said to himself, 'would spoil all; D'Artagnan, my friend, prove to this young serpent that thou art not only stronger, but more subtle than he is.'

'Ah!' he said, making a low bow, 'why did you not begin by saying that, Monsieur Mordaunt? What! are you sent by General Oliver Cromwell, the most illustrious captain of the age?'

'I have this instant left him,' replied Mordaunt, alighting, in order to give his horse to a soldier to hold.

D'Artagnan said nothing, but, after having gnawed the flower stalk, he began to bite his nails. At last:

'Do you imagine,' he resumed, 'that they mean to kill you? And wherefore should they do so? What interest have they in your death? Moreover, you are *our* prisoners.'

'Fool!' cried Aramis; 'knowest thou not, then, Mordaunt? I have but exchanged with him one look, yet that look convinced me that we were doomed.'

'The truth is, I'm very sorry that I did not strangle him as you advised me,' said Porthos.

'Eh! I make no account of the harm Mordaunt can do!' cried D'Artagnan. '*Cap de Diou!* if he troubles me too much I will crush him, the insect! Do not fly, then. It is useless; for I swear to you that you are as safe here as you were twenty years, ago—you, Athos, in the Rue Ferou, and you, Aramis, in the Rue de Vaugirard.'

'Stop,' cried Athos, extending his hand to one of the grated windows by which the room was lighted; 'you will soon know what to expect, for here he is.'

'Who?'

'Mordaunt.'

In fact, looking at the place to which Athos pointed, D'Artagnan saw a cavalier coming toward the house at full gallop.

It was Mordaunt.

D'Artagnan rushed out of the room.

Porthos wanted to follow him.

'Stay,' said D'Artagnan, 'and do not come till you hear me drum my fingers on the door.'

When Mordaunt arrived opposite the house he saw D'Artagnan on the threshold and the soldiers lying on the grass here and there, with their arms.

'Halloo!' he cried, 'are the prisoners still there?'

'Yes, sir,' answered the sergeant, uncovering.

''Tis well; order four men to conduct them to my lodging.'

Four men prepared to do so.

'What is it?' said D'Artagnan, with that jeering manner which our readers have so often observed in him since they made his acquaintance. 'What is the matter, if you please?'

Chapter LX

Respect to Fallen Majesty

As our fugitives approached the house, they found the ground cut up, as if a considerable body of horsemen had preceded them. Before the door the traces were yet more apparent; these horsemen, whoever they might be, had halted there.

'Egad!' cried D'Artagnan, 'it's quite clear that the king and his escort have been by here.'

'The devil!' said Porthos; 'in that case they have eaten everything.'

'Bah!' said D'Artagnan, 'they will have left a chicken, at least.' He dismounted and knocked on the door. There was no response.

He pushed open the door and found the first room empty and deserted.

'Well?' cried Porthos.

'I can see nobody,' said D'Artagnan. 'Aha!'

'What?'

'Blood!'

At this word the three friends leaped from their horses and entered. D'Artagnan had already opened the door of the second room, and from the expression of his face it was clear that he there beheld some extraordinary object.

The three friends drew near and discovered a young man stretched on the ground, bathed in a pool of blood. It was evident that he had attempted to regain his bed, but had not had sufficient strength to do so.

Athos, who imagined that he saw him move, was the first to go up to him.

'Well?' inquired D'Artagnan.

'Well, if he is dead,' said Athos, 'he has not been so long, for he is still warm. But no, his heart is beating. Ho, there, my friend!'

The wounded man heaved a sigh. D'Artagnan took some water in the hollow of his hand and threw it upon his face. The man opened his eyes, made an effort to raise his head, and fell back again. The wound was in the top of his skull and blood was flawing copiously.

Aramis dipped a cloth into some water and applied it to the gash. Again the wounded man opened his eyes and looked in astonishment at these strangers, who appeared to pity him.

'You are among friends,' said Athos, in English; 'so cheer up, and tell us, if you have the strength to do so, what has happened?'

'The king,' muttered the wounded man, 'the king is a prisoner.'

'You have seen him?' asked Aramis, in the same language.

The man made no reply.

'Make your mind easy,' resumed Athos, 'we are all faithful servants of his majesty.'

'Is what you tell me true?' asked the wounded man.

'On our honour as gentlemen.'

'Then I may tell you all. I am brother to Parry, his majesty's lackey.'

Athos and Aramis remembered that this was the name by which De Winter had called the man they had found in the passage of the king's tent.

'We know him,' said Athos, 'he never left the king.'

'Yes, that is he. Well, he thought of me, when he saw the king was taken, and as they were passing before the house he begged in the king's name that they would stop, as the king was hungry. They brought him into this room and placed sentinels at the doors and windows. Parry knew this room, as he had often been to see me when the king was at Newcastle. He knew that there was a trap-door communicating with a cellar, from which one could get into the orchard. He made a sign, which I understood, but the king's guards must have noticed it and held themselves on guard. I went out as if to fetch wood, passed through the subterranean passage into the cellar, and whilst Parry was gently bolting the door, pushed up the board and beckoned to the king to follow me. Alas! he would not. But Parry clasped his hands and implored him, and at last he agreed. I went on first, fortunately. The king was a few steps behind me, when suddenly I saw something rise up in front of me like a huge shadow. I wanted to cry out to warn the king, but that very moment I felt a blow as if the house was falling on my head, and fell insensible. When I came

'However that may be, D'Artagnan,' replied Athos, without falling into the snare which his Gascon friend had prepared for him by an appeal to his parental love, 'however that may be, you know in the bottom of your heart that it is true; but I am wrong to dispute with my master. D'Artagnan, I am your prisoner—treat me as such.'

'Ah! *pardieu!*' said D'Artagnan, 'you know you will not be my prisoner very long.'

'No,' said Aramis, 'they will doubtless treat us like the prisoners of the Philipghauts.'

'And how were they treated?' asked D'Artagnan.

'Why,' said Aramis, 'one-half were hanged and the other half were shot.'

'Well, I,' said D'Artagnan 'I answer that while there remains a drop of blood in my veins you will be neither hanged nor shot. *Sang Diou!* let them come on! Besides—do you see that door, Athos?'

'Yes; what then?'

'Well, you can go out by that door whenever you please; for from this moment you are free as the air.'

'I recognise you there, my brave D'Artagnan,' replied Athos; 'but you are no longer our masters. That door is guarded, D'Artagnan; you know that.'

'Very well, you will force it,' said Porthos. 'There are only a dozen men at the most.'

'That would be nothing for us four; it is too much for us two. No, divided as we now are, we must perish. See the fatal example: on the Vendômois road, D'Artagnan, you so brave, and you, Porthos, so valiant and so strong—you were beaten; to-day Aramis and I are beaten in our turn. Now that never happened to us when we were four together. Let us die, then, as De Winter has died; as for me, I will fly only on condition that we all fly together.'

'Impossible,' said D'Artagnan; 'we are under Mazarin's orders.'

'I know it and I have nothing more to say; my arguments lead to nothing; doubtless they are bad, since they have not determined minds so just as yours.'

'Besides,' said Aramis, 'had they taken effect it would be still better not to compromise two excellent friends like D'Artagnan and Porthos. Be assured, gentlemen, we shall do you honour in our dying. As for myself, I shall be proud to face the bullets, or even the rope, in company with you, Athos; for you have never seemed to me so grand as you are to-day.'